NICK FURY



"There was something that was quintessentially Marvel about what Stan [Lee] and Jack [Kirby] did," says Ralph Macchio of Nick Fury. Fury was introduced as the leader of a ragtag, over-the-top World War II squad in Sgt. Fury and His Howling Commandos #1 (May 1963). But it was only a few months later that Fury showed up in the present day. "They took a guy from World War II," Macchio continues, "upgraded him, updated him, made him a CIA agent, but then they put him in charge of this globe-girdling organization in S.H.I.E.L.D. And he was not the suave, debonair, James Bond type, or even the M type who would run things. He was still a hard-bitten, rough-around-the-edges character."

Writer/artist Jim Steranko gave Fury a makeover in the late 1960s, increasing the character's sophistication. Initially, the present-day Fury was simply a WWII vet—no older than Jack Kirby, who also served in the war. But as time continued, and WWII faded further into the past, the aging spy was revealed to be maintaining his youth chemically, with the "Infinity Formula."

"I think the way Nick has grown over the years," recalls Macchio, "is that he has gotten into the games of death and deceit and now himself has become quite a schemer and manuverer, which I don't think he was in the beginning." Today, Fury has adapted to the machinations of the spy world and is a major player in the Marvel Universe.



When Marvel launched revamped versions of some of its characters in the early 21st century, with the "Ultimate" line of comics, Fury soon became the leader of the Avengers analogue, The Ultimates, in the eponymous series by Mark Millar and Bryan Hitch.



Though the African-American Ultimate Fury first appeared in Ultimate Marvel Team-Up #5, by Brian Michael Bendis and Mike Allred, it was in Ultimates that he really came into his own.

When it came time to cast the leader of S.H.I.E.L.D. (Strategic Homeland Intervention, Enforcement, and Logistics Division) in the films for an after-credits sequence of Iron Man, Jeremy Latcham calls the decision to go with Samuel L. Jackson "an obvious choice. We thought fans would go crazy if Sam Jackson showed up with an eye patch and he looked so much like the character from the comic books."

Art by Jim Steranko (left), David Finch (middle), Bryan Hitch (right).